

YOUR ROOTS ARE SHOWING

I grew up in a one-story red-roof house in Hollywood, Florida, with my mom, my dad, my older brother, and my younger sister. Our house was on Fillmore Street, in a line of streets named for the US presidents. (That explains why I know something about our thirteenth president, Millard Fillmore, last of the Whig party.)

It was a warm house and very lived in—lots of sports memorabilia on the walls and records lying around and a fish tank and trunks full of dress-up old clothing. The floors were yellow tile, with occasional little leaf designs painted on here and there.

The backyard had a banana tree, an avocado tree, and a grapefruit tree. I could climb to my heart's content, and we could practically live off the land. (I thought every salad had all three ingredients until high school.) My dad had dug up the front yard and put in sand and mulch. He planted cacti and Joshua trees and “tumbleweeds” to make it look like a Wild West scene. It was the only house on the block without a normal yard, and sometimes I'd catch people driving by just to marvel at it. When I didn't know about other people's houses, I thought ours was the best one in the world.

When I was 15, my dad was struggling to figure out his job situation, and we had to move. My brother, 30 then, had gone to New York City. My grandmother, who'd lived with us for a while, had passed away after a terrible battle with cancer. It was just me, my sister, my dad, and my mom with both an extra bedroom and a big, beautiful backyard we didn't “need.”

My dad tells me they bought that house in 1987 for \$170,000. (By comparison, the houses I look at now on Zillow on Los Angeles' East Side are often \$1 million or more. Oh, the '80s. You were prosperous.) We then sold the Fillmore Street house for \$350,000 in 2002. At the time, my parents also took my younger sister out of an expensive private school—which we couldn't afford